



LOST CHALLENGE: Mallya (centre) in the days he was proud to stand by his team

players that I wanted... Unfortunately in cricket, the captain is the boss."

VIJAY MALLYA, OWNER, BANGALORE ROYAL CHALLENGERS

in panic during a game, saying he thought his team were a man short. Quickly, two minions launched on a panicky head-count to reassure the boss. When rousing cheers for Lasith Malinga rang out, it was pointed out that the man being cheered was not the unmistakable Malinga with the curly bottle-blond tints, but Dilhara Fernando.

The end of IPL on June 1 will signal the beginning of the franchise's own financial reckoning. Already there are rumblings about cutbacks: Delhi has got rid of its cheerleading squad saying they were no longer needed. Two teams—the King's XI Punjab and the Kolkata Knight Riders (KKR)—‘released’ their contracted players, on grounds that they needed to concentrate on the core team as the semi-finals drew close. KKR team director Joy Bhattacharjya

denied cost-cutting. Keeping six more players on the squad until the end of IPL, he said, would have amounted to an expense of Rs 1.2 lakh more. “That’s peanuts. Why would we do something that would cause a major PR issue in order to save peanuts? That would not be ruthless, that would be stupid.” King’s XI CEO Neil Maxwell said his team had taken on an extended player pool to give locals a chance to work with the world’s leading cricketers for a specific period. “We were trying to do the right thing and had to deal with a backlash instead.”

For overseas players—and the vast cast of foreign coaches—IPL is just an opportunity to swirl right in with India’s cricketing circus, earn generous pay packets and enjoy the late-night post-game parties. India’s stars, though, feel the change in temperatures acutely.

When Sourav Ganguly’s KKR lost three matches in a row, a teammate watching him in his next game remarked, “The only time I’ve seen Sourav so much under pressure was in the World Cup final.” Indian cricket’s biggest names are feeling the weight of their enormous salaries, dealing with bean counters rather than selectors as judges and playing the fastest and least familiar format of the game, with its low comeback rate. A franchise executive says, “It’s almost as if the players are more tense in IPL than with India—this is cricket at its most commercial and every one is feeling jumpy.”

Inadvertently, Vijay Mallya’s I-was-robbed routine has put the franchise’s alter ego on mainstage. Cricketers are discovering that the smiling fan with the fat cheque book can also become the cry-baby boss with the pink slip. ■